



Axiotron Modbook

Never heard of it? It's a custom works company that converts a Mac Book laptop into a pen-based Mac tablet.



Microsoft Courier

Not a direct competitor to the iPad, this foldable tablet offers some unique use case scenarios. But it's rumoured to be cancelled.

iPad Killers?

The iPad seems to be the undisputed ruler of the tablet kingdom. We take a look at ten of the most promising contenders for this coveted throne

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A number of eminent sources have proclaimed 2010 to be the year of the tablet. When we spoke to Paul Lee, Director, Deloitte International research, he was very optimistic about NetTabs being 'just right' for tens of millions of consumers in 2010. They're bigger than a smartphone and much more portable than netbooks. Yet when we look at the current scenario, the Apple iPad overshadows every other tablet offering in the market, selling more than 3,00,000 units just on debut.

Perhaps there is a need to answer some of the more fundamental questions - what makes a good tablet and what kind of platforms exist in the tablet space? A tablet is a touch screen device, usually in the vicinity of 7 to 11 inches in size, meant for consuming internet and multimedia content. The large screen size offers a unique proposition of viewing video, ebooks and the possibility of handheld gaming. Currently, there seem to be three emerging schools of thought when it comes to tablet environments. One is the Apple way of doing things - excellent hardware and 'there's an app for everything' interface design. The other is the Android + Tegra 2 combination. These devices work on the Android operating system which is also designed for touch, with the added advantage of Flash support when it comes to online browsing. The Tegra 2 chip from NVIDIA is also powerful enough to run HD video without any hiccups and runs games

beautifully. The last format of tablet computing is Windows based. Manufacturers try to cram a whole computer into a tablet form factor to give users a more complete PC experience, enabling USB ports, Flash support and access to the vast already existing software in the wild. These devices usually run on the Intel x86 Atom platform with Windows 7. The flagship product following this format was the HP Slate, which many felt was a strong contender to be the one true iPad killer. Unfortunately HP conceded defeat even before entering the fray with the premature discontinuation of the Slate project. The trouble was that Windows 7 inherently is not designed for touch input and the underlying hardware reportedly rendered the Slate a slow and handicapped version of a PC. Does that mean the iPad is the undisputed ruler of the Tablet space? Certainly not. There are a lot of contenders entering the fray with unique offerings - from our very own Indian Notion Inc with Adam to established biggies like Dell with the Mini 5 Streak. Here we look at the top 10 devices - either already available or soon to be released - that are likely to compete with the iPad.

Notion Ink Adam

The most promising contender so far and one that is close to our hearts owing to its Indian origin. The Adam is leaps and bounds ahead of others when it comes to



Notion Ink Adam



Archos 9

Archos 9 PTablet

Archos traditionally has been one of the companies to come out with compelling PMPs that gave a sound alternative to the iPod back in the day. The Archos 9 seems to be such an offering from the company to try and take on the iPad. It runs on Windows 7 and offers all the advantages, and disadvantages that come with it. There seems to be no attempt to make the OS touch friendly. It runs on a 1.2GHz Atom processor and features a 8.9-inch LED backlight resistive screen, Wi-Fi and an ethernet port - an oddity on a tablet. The 60 GB version is available for £459.77.

Eee Pad



ASUS Eee Pad

When the company that essentially created the market for netbooks announces that it's going to launch a killer product soon, we sit up and take notice. Accordingly at Computex 2010 it unveiled the Eee Pad. It comes in two variants the 12 inch EP 121 and the 10 inch EP 101. The larger screen variant comes with Windows 7 and is powered by a CULV Intel Core 2 Duo processor promising 10 hours of battery life. It also has an innovative hybrid keyboard/docking station design. The smaller variant comes with Windows Embedded Compact 7. The estimated price is to be \$399 but the bad news is that the Eee Pads will go on sale only next year.